

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Customer Success English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For customer success managers, account managers, onboarding specialists, support escalation leads, renewals managers, implementation teams, and post-sale revenue leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Onboarding kickoff

02 Interpreting account health

03 Support escalation

04 Quarterly business review

05 Renewal risk

06 Expansion fit

07 Feature request handoff

08 Resetting communication expectations

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Onboarding kickoff

Customer success and implementation define responsibilities.

Roles: Customer success manager / Implementation lead

Customer success manager: The customer expects to go live in three weeks. What must they provide before configuration starts?

Implementation lead: Approved requirements, an integration contact, and suitable test data through the agreed channel.

Customer success manager: I'll put those dependencies in the success plan with named owners.

Implementation lead: Include acceptance criteria and the point at which we reassess the timeline if inputs are late.

Customer success manager: We'll review the plan with the customer at kickoff.

Implementation lead: Good. A target date should come with visible responsibilities, not an unqualified promise.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The customer expects to go live in three weeks. What must they provide before configuration starts?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Interpreting account health

Two teams review a low health score.

Roles: Customer success manager / Customer operations analyst

Customer success manager: This account's health score dropped, but the sponsor says they're satisfied.

Customer operations analyst: The score is driven by login frequency. Their workflow may only require monthly use.

Customer success manager: Then we need to compare adoption with the intended use case.

Customer operations analyst: I'll check key actions, data completeness, and how the model weights the signals.

Customer success manager: I'll discuss actual outcomes with the customer rather than tell them a score proves dissatisfaction.

Customer operations analyst: We'll document the context and review whether the health model needs adjustment.

Notice the professional language

health score - A defined summary indicator used to assess the state of a customer account.

use case - A specific situation describing how someone uses a product or service to achieve a goal.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Support escalation

Customer success requests an update on an unresolved incident.

Roles: Customer success manager / Support incident lead

Customer success manager: The customer needs an update before their operations meeting. What is confirmed?

Support incident lead: The affected workflow is identified, and mitigation is being evaluated. We don't have a verified resolution time.

Customer success manager: Can I say the workaround is ready?

Support incident lead: Not yet. Engineering is checking its limitations and suitability.

Customer success manager: I'll explain the current impact and give a time for the next update.

Support incident lead: I'll own the technical follow-up and provide approved customer wording when the mitigation is confirmed.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The customer needs an update before their operations meeting. What is confirmed?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Quarterly business review

An account team prepares an outcome-focused review.

Roles: Account manager / Customer success manager

Account manager: Our deck has twenty slides of usage charts. What business outcome are we discussing?

Customer success manager: The customer's goal was faster case handling. We should compare that measure with the agreed baseline.

Account manager: Do we have comparable data and the customer's confirmation of the definition?

Customer success manager: I'll verify both and show any gaps openly.

Account manager: Then end with the decisions and actions needed for the next quarter.

Customer success manager: Agreed. Product activity is useful context, but it doesn't automatically establish customer value.

Notice the professional language

business outcome - A result the organization wants to achieve through its work.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Renewal risk

An account team reviews a late renewal.

Roles: Renewals manager / Customer success manager

Renewals manager: The renewal date is close, but procurement hasn't responded. Should I mark the account as lost?

Customer success manager: Not from silence alone. The sponsor says a budget review is underway.

Renewals manager: What is the confirmed buying process and decision date?

Customer success manager: I'll ask the sponsor and identify the procurement contact, without treating interest as approval.

Renewals manager: I'll keep the forecast status aligned with the evidence.

Customer success manager: We'll record the unresolved risks and the next agreed customer contact.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The renewal date is close, but procurement hasn't responded. Should I mark the account as lost?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Expansion fit

A sales colleague proposes an upgrade to a struggling customer.

Roles: Expansion manager / Customer success manager

Expansion manager: The premium plan could solve their reporting request. Shall I send an upgrade proposal?

Customer success manager: First confirm the need and whether the current plan already supports an acceptable solution.

Expansion manager: They also haven't completed the original onboarding.

Customer success manager: Then adoption barriers deserve attention before we imply that more spend is the answer.

Expansion manager: I'll ask the solutions team to compare the actual options.

Customer success manager: We'll explain the fit, limits, and costs clearly and let the customer assess them against their priorities.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The premium plan could solve their reporting request. Shall I send an upgrade proposal?"
What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Feature request handoff

Customer success passes a customer request to product.

Roles: Customer success manager / Product manager

Customer success manager: Three customers asked for a bulk approval button. I've attached examples of their current workflow.

Product manager: What task is slow, how often does it occur, and what constraints affect approval?

Customer success manager: They review hundreds of records, but different records may require different authority.

Product manager: That means a simple bulk action may introduce errors. Let's investigate the underlying need.

Customer success manager: I'll arrange discovery calls and avoid promising a delivery date.

Product manager: I'll record the evidence and keep you informed about the prioritization decision.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What task is slow, how often does it occur, and what constraints affect approval?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Resetting communication expectations

An account team addresses repeated requests outside service hours.

Roles: Customer success manager / Support manager

Customer success manager: The customer expects immediate replies from my personal phone every weekend.

Support manager: Explain the agreed support channels and escalation process, and acknowledge any earlier wording that created confusion.

Customer success manager: I'll distinguish urgent service incidents from routine account questions.

Support manager: Make sure the approved channel is usable and the actual coverage is clear.

Customer success manager: I'll offer a call to agree on a practical communication plan.

Support manager: I'll join to confirm support arrangements and follow up on any gap in the contracted service.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The customer expects immediate replies from my personal phone every weekend." What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Onboarding and Implementation Expectations

SHARED CASE

A customer expects to go live next Friday, but data migration responsibilities and training dates are still unassigned.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What needs to be complete for you to consider the launch ready? Let's confirm the migration owner and training dates before treating next Friday as a committed go-live date.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Adoption Metrics and Health Scores

SHARED CASE

An account has many logins but little use of the workflow it purchased the product to improve.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Logins show activity, but they do not tell us whether the intended workflow is being adopted. Let's review the relevant usage and ask the customer about the outcome they are trying to achieve.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Support Escalations and Incident Communication

SHARED CASE

A customer issue has a verified workaround but no confirmed permanent-fix date.
A draft update promises a fix tomorrow.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

We have a verified workaround, but the permanent-fix date is not confirmed. I'll explain the workaround and state the next update time without promising an unverified resolution date.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

QBRs and Business Outcomes

SHARED CASE

A business review claims a large return on investment using estimated time savings that the customer has not validated.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Cover this until after your first attempt

The return estimate depends on unverified time-saving assumptions. Let's review those assumptions with the customer and label the result as an estimate rather than a demonstrated outcome.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Renewals and Churn Risk

SHARED CASE

An account renews in six weeks. The main contact has changed, and the team has not confirmed current priorities.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could we arrange a review with the current decision makers to confirm priorities and unresolved issues? That will help us understand the renewal discussion before assuming the previous plan still fits.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Expansion and Upsell Ethics

SHARED CASE

A customer is considering more licenses while many existing users have not completed onboarding.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

Additional licenses may be useful, but adoption of the current ones is still incomplete. Let's compare expansion with improving onboarding against the customer's immediate goals before recommending the next purchase.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Product Feedback and Feature Requests

SHARED CASE

A customer asks for a specific feature, but the product team needs to understand the underlying workflow and current obstacle.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

What task are you trying to complete, and what prevents you from doing it today? I'll record the workflow and impact so the product team can evaluate the request without treating a proposed feature as the only solution.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Difficult Customers and Boundary Setting

SHARED CASE

A frustrated customer says a feature was promised for this month. The record contains an estimate, not a confirmed commitment.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

I understand why you expected it this month. The earlier wording did not clearly distinguish an estimate from a commitment. I'll clarify the current status and discuss the available options with the responsible team.

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.